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IN 2019, US banking major Bank of America (BoFA), which has its India head office in Mumbai, decided to commence its investment banking practice in Bengaluru, India's unicorn hub. Since then, BoFA has doubled the strength of its investment banking team in Bengaluru as it eyes a bigger slice of the start-up space. This comes at a time when the volatile stock markets have played spoilsport in many a unicorn's journey of going public and the ventures have been forced to go back to private equity or venture capital players. "We were the first bank to have an investment banking team in Bengaluru focussed on the unicorn space. We believe it is important to be present in an ecosystem that is enabling the rise of new-age companies," says Kaku Nakhate, President & India Country Head, BoFA.

Not far from BoFA's office in Mumbai's BKC is the office of another US banking major, JPMorgan Chase Bank India, that has been steadily expanding its commercial banking practice. The aim is to serve local mid-cap companies while making huge investments in the payments and transaction banking vertical to help digitise its MNC and e-commerce clients to better manage their cross-border flows, among other things.

US banking majors are not the only ones active in India. Germany's Deutsche Bank Group recently launched its IFSC Banking Unit or IBU in Gujarat's GIFT City, the country's first International Financial Services Centre (IFSC). And HSBC India, whose parent is headquartered in London, is trying to be a "more Indian" bank, according to CEO Hitendra Dave. "We are in the midst of very significant customer acquisition across all segments... We are spending money to attract customers... The real opportunity for us is to just acquire customers at a very rapid scale. We are resetting



STANDARD CHARTERED

- ▶ India debut: 1858
- ▶ Size of balance sheet: ₹1,75,938 crore

KEY FOCUS AREAS:

- ▶ Retail banking
- ▶ Innovative, digital solutions
- ▶ MNCs, corporates, institutions
- ▶ Unsecured lending

"We are present in 42 locations in India, which is good enough. Nearly 70 per cent of the business that happens in India happens in those 42 locations. So, it's fine"

ZARIN DARUWALA
CLUSTER CEO, INDIA
AND SOUTH ASIA MARKETS,
STANDARD CHARTERED BANK

our aspirations and our ambitions in the country... The high-level strategies—significant expansion in customers on the back of that very meaningful desire to grow our balance sheet—[will help us] become a much more Indian bank," Dave told *BT* in a recent interaction.

Meanwhile, British major Standard Chartered Bank, a full-service bank in India, is eyeing a bigger slice of the retail space, especially with the exit of Citi.

This assumes significance as a few months ago,